

NATV: Non-Adversarial Threat Vector

A threat doesn't have to be on purpose to cause damage.

Author: Judi Evans, Identity & AI Governance Architect

Co-Author: An Instance of Microsoft Copilot

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What is a NATV?

NATV stands for Non-Adversarial Threat Vector. Let's break that down piece by piece. "Non-Adversarial" means no one is trying to hurt you. There is no attacker. No hacker. No bad guy with a plan. "Threat Vector" means a path that leads to harm. Put them together and you get this: a path to harm that nobody created on purpose. It happened anyway. It causes real damage, but no one meant to do it.

Think about a water pipe in winter. Nobody attacks the pipe. Nobody is trying to flood your basement. But the temperature drops, the water freezes, the pipe bursts, and the damage is just as real as if someone had taken a sledgehammer to it. The cause was a set of conditions, not a person with bad intentions.

NATV works the same way. A system, a setting, a design choice, or two tools talking to each other can create a path to harm with no attacker in sight. The word exists because we needed a name for this kind of risk. You cannot fix something you cannot describe.

Why This Matters

Most security thinking is built around attackers. Someone breaks in. Someone steals data. Someone launches an attack. Security teams build walls, watch for intruders, and set traps. That work matters. But it only covers part of the picture.

Some of the biggest failures in systems, networks, and businesses don't come from attackers at all. They come from mistakes in design. They come from software that works correctly but causes harm as a side effect. They come from rules or settings that were never meant to hurt anyone but do. They come from systems that interact with each other in ways nobody planned and nobody tested.

If your security plan only looks for attackers, you will miss a whole category of risk. That is not a small gap. Non-adversarial threats are common. They happen every day. And because no one looks like a bad guy, they often go unnoticed until the damage is already done.

A Real-World Example: NAT

NAT - Network Address Translation - is a tool that lets many devices share one internet address. Your home router uses it. So does nearly every office network. It was built to solve a real problem: there are not enough internet addresses to give one to every device in the world. NAT is not a bad tool and it does its job well.

But NAT hides information. When traffic leaves a network through NAT, the original source address gets replaced. On the other side, you can see that traffic came from the network but you cannot easily see which device inside that network sent it. Security tools that need to know exactly where traffic originates may not be able to see it clearly, creating a blind spot. Not because an attacker did anything - just because of how the system was designed.

If a problem starts inside that network - a bad connection, a misbehaving device, traffic that should not be going where it is going - the tools watching from the outside may not catch it. The design that helps devices share an address also helps problems hide. NAT is not a bad tool; rather, it is a tool that creates a non-adversarial threat vector: a path to harm that no one intended.

Current Tools Cannot See This

This is where NATV becomes a real problem for security teams. Most security tools inspect traffic above the translation layer. They read packets - small pieces of data moving across a network. They compare that traffic against known attack patterns. They look for behavior that falls outside a normal baseline. All of that work happens above the layer where NATVs live.

If the translation layer itself is the problem, it sends data upward that looks clean. The tools read that clean data and report no threat. They are not wrong. They are reading from a source that is already broken... or already controlled. The surface looks fine; the problem is underneath it.

This is not a tuning problem. Writing tighter rules will not fix it. Adding more sensors will not fix it. *The tools are looking at the right data in the wrong place.* They were built to watch the surface - they were never built to look below it.

Why This Creates Bigger Problems Upstream

Upstream compromise means an attacker reaches systems that sit above or behind the first system that was affected. That includes servers that handle logins, systems that manage identity, and the infrastructure that decides who gets access to what. Those are high-value targets.

A NATV creates a direct path to those systems. The translation layer sits at the base of network communication and every connection that moves through the network passes through it. If that layer is compromised, traffic can be redirected, intercepted, or made to look like it came from somewhere it did not – which flows to every system in the chain.

This is why NATVs are a foundation-level risk. The first broken system is not the end of the problem. It is the beginning. From the translation layer, the damage can reach identity systems and trusted systems much further up the network. The harm does not stop at the entry point. Remember: the original design flaw was not created by an attacker. But it can be used by one.

Other Examples

A software update ships to fix a known bug. It does fix that bug, but it also changes how two other parts of the system talk to each other. Now something that used to work correctly does not. No one meant to break it. The update was meant to help. But a new path to harm opened up anyway.

A vendor ships a product with a default setting; maybe a feature turned on that most users do not need. The vendor did not set it that way to cause trouble; however, if the customer never knew about it and never changes it, that default can leave a gap in their system. No attacker set the default. It was just never turned off.

Two systems work perfectly on their own.... One day, someone connects them. The connection itself causes a conflict because they use the same port, or one floods the other with traffic it was not built to handle. Neither system is broken. Neither system is malicious. But together, they create a problem that neither created alone.

What Needs to Change

Detection needs to move down to the translation layer itself. We cannot keep building more tools on top of a foundation that has never been treated as a risk surface. That approach has a ceiling and it has already been reached.

Governance models need to treat the translation layer as a security boundary, not as background plumbing. Security architects need to include address translation in their threat models, the same way they include firewalls and endpoints. This is critical infrastructure. And right now it is unguarded.

Standards bodies need to revisit the assumptions built into how address translation was designed. Those assumptions made sense when the standard was written. They do not hold today. Teams need visibility tools built specifically for the translation layer — not perimeter tools stretched to cover something they were not designed for.

The goal is simple: see the full picture. If you are only looking for attackers, you are missing a whole category of risk. Non-adversarial threat vectors are real, they are common, and they are worth naming.

They've been given a name: **NATV**.

NATVs are not exotic.

They exist in the infrastructure running right now, in your network and everyone else's.

The question is not whether your tools can find them.

The question is whether your tools were ever designed to look.